

to be doing this again in a few years because you are missing features you really need.

Continue cycling through this process until you find a house you like. The process can take weeks, or even months. We spoke earlier about narrowing down your options, but if you're already seeing few options that hit all your bases, you should make an offer right away on a home that you like. This is true in any market, but even more so in a seller's market.

You might see a listing online that looks like a winner, but unfortunately, pictures online can vary drastically from real life. (This applies to houses as much as it does to human beings.) Sometimes the listing photographer will use fancy tricks and lenses to make the cupboard under the stairs look like an actual bedroom. This is a pointless trick, since people will see the house in real life and realize it was all a lie—but it will waste your time. And it will be disappointing. You have been warned.

While finding an acceptable home can take weeks or even months, finding *the* one takes thirty to forty-five days of searching on average. The fewer deal breakers you have on your list and the more cities you're open to living in, the easier it will be to find a suitable home. Conversely, the more particular you are, the longer it will take. There is no right answer—you like what you like, and even better, you know what you want. You've set yourself up for success by avoiding any rushed timelines, so if it takes a little while to find your home, that's okay.

JUST SAY NO

Not all homes are created equally. If you're a first-time home buyer, you might be tempted to overlook something that will be a *huge* deal to others. This will affect your ability to sell the house down the road, and you want to consider the future as much as possible.

Here are some properties you should avoid:

- **The house on a busy street.** Not only is there more noise and less privacy, but this can be a safety issue to people with children and pets. Don't take our word for it—Stephen King wrote a whole book about the consequences of living on a busy road. (Spoiler alert: The kid dies, the cat dies, the mom dies, the dad dies; everyone dies.)